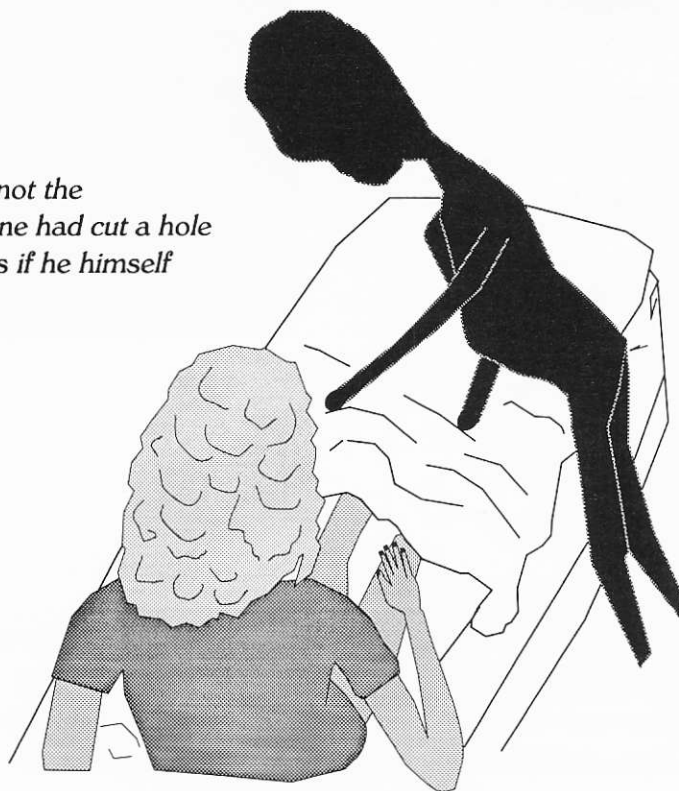
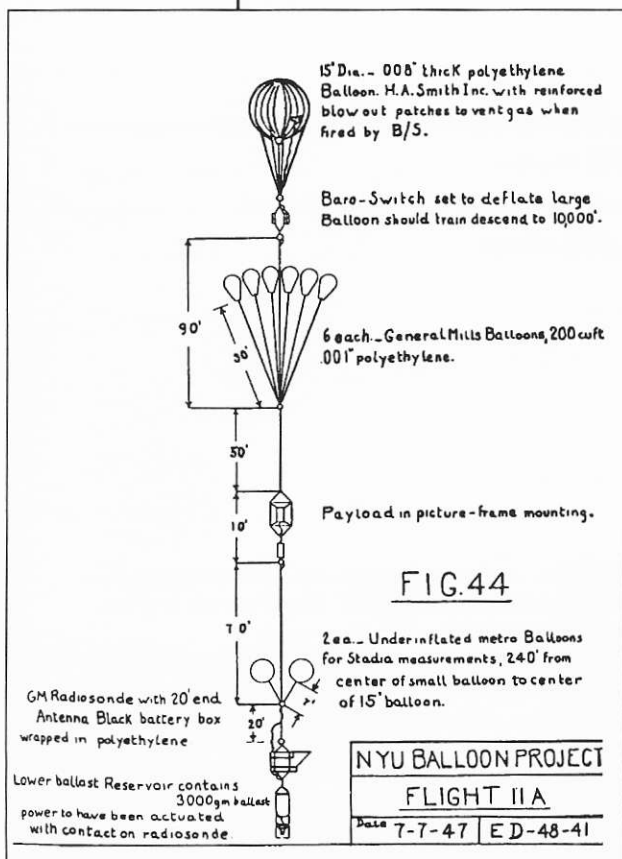


AN EXTRAORDINARY ENCOUNTER IN THE DANDENONG FOOTHILLS

"The creature was black—but not the color black. It was as if someone had cut a hole in matter where he stood or as if he himself was a hole in space."



*"The Third Dreaming."
Based on
sketch by
witness.*



THE AIR FORCE REPORT ON ROSWELL

Project Mogul balloon train launched from Alamogordo, July 7, 1947.

INTERNATIONAL UFO REPORTER

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THE AIR FORCE REPORT ON ROSWELL: AN ABSENCE OF EVIDENCE	by Mark Rodeghier and Mark Chesney	3
AN EXTRAORDINARY ENCOUNTER IN THE DANDENONG FOOTHILLS	by Bill Chalker	4
EPISTEMOLOGICAL TOTALITARISM: THE SKEPTICAL CASE AGAINST ABDUCTIONS	by Thomas E. Bullard	9
SOME WHIMSICAL—AND SERIOUS—REFLECTIONS ON ABDUCTIONS	by Richard Hall	17

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THE AIR FORCE REPORT ON ROSWELL: AN ABSENCE OF EVIDENCE

BY MARK RODEGHIER AND MARK CHESNEY

As almost every reader of *IUR* must know by now, on September 8 of this year, the Air Force released a twenty-three page report, entitled *Report of Air Force Research Regarding the "Roswell Incident."* This report is dated July 1994, contains thirty-three attachments numbering hundreds of additional pages, and purports to "stand as the final official Air Force response regarding this matter." The release of this report and its conclusion—that the Roswell debris came from a top-secret balloon project—was widely reported in the media, including by major television networks and the *New York Times*, which ran a cover story on the report in its Sunday edition.

Despite all this attention, the details of the Air Force report and conclusion have not always been made clear. In this article, we will explain the Air Force conclusion and the reasons they provide to support their theory about Roswell. We will also explain why the Roswell research community finds the Air Force hypothesis so weak and internally inconsistent by focusing on the testimony Air Force investigators gathered from a few carefully-chosen witnesses.

The impetus for the Air Force report was the initiation of a General Accounting Office (GAO) investigation early this year, at the request of Rep. Stephen Schiff from New Mexico, as reported in the March/April issue of *IUR*. It is unusual for a government agency that is currently being investigated by the GAO to release a report to the public, as well as to the GAO, long before a GAO inquiry is complete. However, that is only one of the many oddities surrounding this report, as we demonstrate.

Whatever its content, the Air Force report marks a milestone in ufology: Not since Project Blue Book was closed in 1969 has any agency of the government commented at such length on any UFO incident. That the Air Force was forced to do so says much about the depth of investigation and evidence that affirms the unusual nature of the debris recovered near Roswell in July 1947.

It is impossible to print the report in its entirety in these pages, but we begin by reproducing the Executive Summary to provide a clear statement of the Air Force position.

Mark Rodeghier, Ph.D., is scientific director of the Center for UFO Studies. Mark Chesney is a CUFOS research associate.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The "Roswell Incident" refers to an event that supposedly happened in July, 1947, wherein the Army Air Forces (AAF) allegedly recovered remains of a crashed "flying disc" near Roswell, New Mexico. In February, 1994, the General Accounting Office (GAO), acting on the request of a New Mexico Congressman, initiated an audit to attempt to locate records of such an incident and to determine if records regarding it were properly handled. Although the GAO effort was to look at a number of government agencies, the apparent focus was on the Air Force. SAF/AAZ [Security and Special Program Oversight, Office of the Secretary of the Air Force], as the Central Point of Contact for the GAO in this matter, initiated a systematic search of current Air Force offices as well as numerous archives and records centers that might help explain this matter. Research revealed that the "Roswell Incident" was not even considered a UFO event until the 1978–1980 time frame. Prior to that, the incident was dismissed because the AAF originally identified the debris recovered as being that of a weather balloon. Subsequently, various authors wrote a number of books claiming that, not only was debris from an alien spacecraft recovered, but also the bodies of the craft's alien occupants. These claims continue to evolve today and the Air Force is now routinely accused of engaging in a "cover-up" of this supposed event.

The research located no records at existing Air Force offices that indicated any "cover-up" by the USAF or any indication of such a recovery. Consequently, efforts were intensified by Air Force researchers at numerous locations where records for the period in question were stored. The records reviewed did not reveal any increase in operations, security, or any other activity in July, 1947, that indicated any such unusual event may have occurred. Records were located and thoroughly explored concerning a then-TOP SECRET balloon project, designed to attempt to monitor Soviet nuclear tests, known as Project Mogul. Additionally, several surviving project personnel were located and interviewed, as was the only surviving person who recovered debris from the original Roswell site in 1947, and the former

continued on page 20

AN EXTRAORDINARY ENCOUNTER IN THE DANDENONG FOOTHILLS

BY BILL CHALKER

As a scientist I am always aware of the maxim that extraordinary claims require extraordinary evidence. To date mainstream UFO events have revealed some compelling evidence for their physical reality. The challenge for researchers has always been to determine if that evidence is consistent with an alien reality. Comparable evidence to support the reality of abduction events has been lacking or relatively unconvincing.

In my two decades of research into Australian abduction claims, it has been difficult not to hold the position that abduction cases have perhaps told me more about the human condition than they have about UFOs. What follows, however, is a report on an affair which may amount to evidence for a reality behind abduction reports.

Kelly Cahill, a 27-year-old housewife and mother of three children, is a pivotal figure in a remarkable episode which may have much to tell experiencers and researchers alike. She contacted me on October 4, 1993, seeking assistance in understanding a bizarre experience she underwent near the outer Melbourne suburban housing estate of Narre Warren North, in the foothills of the Dandenongs, Victoria, between Belgrave and Fountain Gate, during the early hours of August 8, 1993.

Kelly told me that apart from her husband with her in their car, she was aware of another vehicle farther down the hill from their own position. That car contained at least two persons, a man and a woman. She paid little heed to them at the time because she and her husband had their attention riveted on a massive UFO which had landed in the field opposite them.

Because Kelly lived in Victoria and I live in New South Wales, I passed details of Kelly's experience on to John Auchettl of Phenomena Research Australia (PRA) and urged Kelly to contact him. PRA got on the case immediately.

By November 17 PRA had located the man and woman Kelly had seen that night. It turned out that the couple also

had a friend (a woman) with them. These witnesses took Auchettl to the encounter site, to a spot consistent with Kelly's description. The group's drawings of the UFO and entities also closely coincide with Kelly's.

Here we have a striking situation. Two groups of persons unknown to each other have witnessed the same UFO encounter and entities. They also experienced missing time, and each group has been available to competent investigators. *Independent* witnesses have provided information which enable cross-checking and correlations to reveal a remarkable amount of similar information. The result is a compelling case for the reality of the strange events described. The ontological status of the events is further strengthened by a range of apparently related physical traces, including ground traces, a magnetic anomaly, and effects on some of the witnesses.

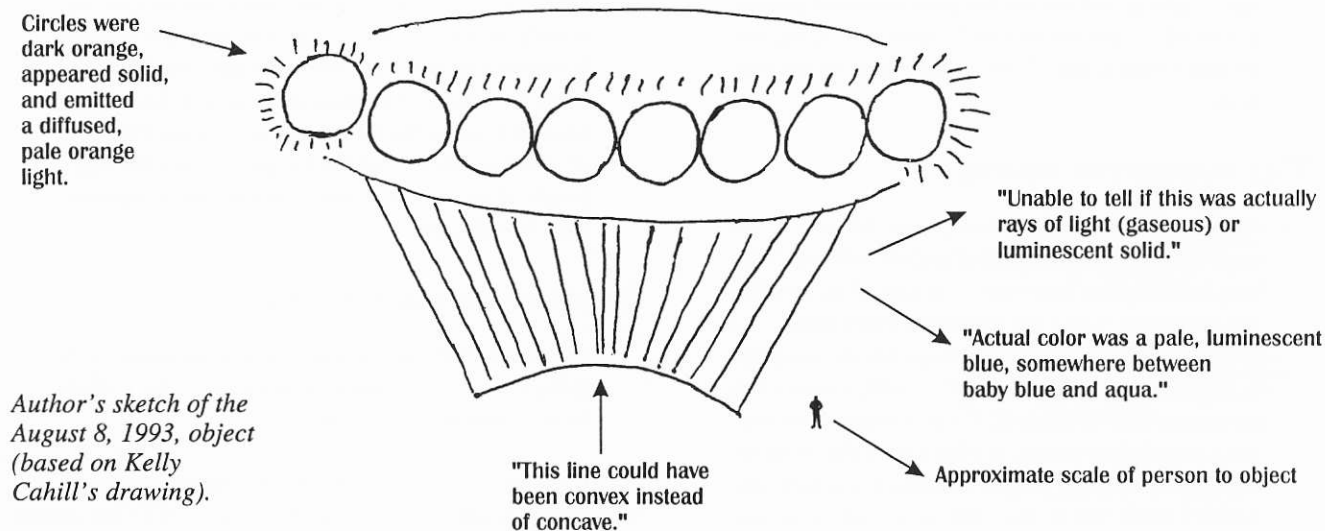
What is perhaps even more extraordinary about this case is that the second group described seeing yet another car parked farther back down from them. In it was (it appeared) one male who seemed to be gazing fixedly toward the encounter site. So we have the situation of three cars present: Kelly and her husband in one near the top of a hill, the three-person group (Bill, Jan, and Glenda) another 150 meters down the hill, and the other car, with one visible occupant, about 25 to 30 meters farther back.

The first two cars were parked with their lights off. The other had its lights on. This circumstance may explain an apparent anomaly, in that Kelly was able to glance down and spot the second car, with what to her seemed only two persons (in fact three), but the group of three could not see Kelly, her husband, or their car. It was a dark and cloudy night. Evidently Kelly could see the second car only because it was backlit by the headlights of the third car.

From the trio's testimony, investigators could determine the location of this third car. The male was looking at the UFO's position through a break in the vegetation cover. The trio's evidence coupled with Kelly's allowed for triangulation of the encounter site with the UFO. The location was consistent with the anomalies discovered (to be discussed later). Unfortunately, this potential additional witness has yet to be found.

Typically witnesses to these sorts of events are known to each other, and such relationships often beg the question of whether the witnessed events have emerged from shared

John Auchettl and PRA can be contacted at Box 523, Mulgrave North, Victoria 3170, Australia. Bill Chalker, an IUR contributing editor, coordinates the UFO Investigation Center (UFOIC). His address is Box W 42, West Pennant Hills, New South Wales 2125, Australia.



delusions or even collusion. Through Auchettl, Kelly became aware of the independent witnesses, but they knew nothing of her existence until quite recently. Kelly tried hard to persuade Auchettl to give her the other group's names, but he refused because he wanted to maintain the integrity of the testimony. Only when the investigation was completed did the three learn what Kelly had been saying. So far they have not attempted to contact her. PRA has uncovered no evidence of a previous connection between the Cahills and the other group.

After the encounter Kelly's recollection faded from conscious memory, despite animated discussions about it with her husband in the immediate wake of the incident. Her husband remembered at least the UFO encounter but not the entities and has not acknowledged the missing time. It was her husband's reference to the August 8 event at a barbecue on September 16 that led to Kelly's initial confused attempts to reconcile this troubling situation. Kelly found this temporary amnesia alarming, especially since she has vivid memories going all the way back to age two.

Other events began to be seen in a different and bizarre perspective. These included a "dream" she had immediately after the encounter, upon getting home and going to sleep on August 8, and two "dreamings" in September. Each involved (apparently) the same entities as those encountered on the road. The latter two "dreamings" had a strange physical dimension. A further two "dreamings" followed, one on October 23 and the last during January 1994.

Alarmed, Kelly sought help with little success from universities and aviation authorities. The latter gave her two UFO contact numbers, one in Victoria and mine in Sydney. After getting no satisfaction from the Victorian group, she contacted me, and after our preliminary discussion of her experience, the PRA investigation commenced.

What follows is the transcript of an interview Kelly gave to my associate Robb Tilley on March 21 of this year. The details are consistent with those recounted to me on

October 4, 1993, in numerous conversations with me since then, with the PRA investigation, and with a manuscript she is writing about her experience.

THE INCIDENT

My husband and I were driving to my girl friend's place up in the mountains. It was her daughter's . . . birthday. It was just after dark, and we were nearly there, about half an hour from her place. It takes us about an hour and a half from our place. It was just after 7.

[The area has] little bits of field . . . and then you run right into a major shopping center. . . .

My husband drives really fast. . . . I'm just busy looking out the window. It's turned dark, and I look over towards this field as we are going past, and I see a ring of orange lights. It was the first time I ever thought I had seen something that wasn't normal. . . . I was going to shut my mouth. I thought, "No, he's just going to have a go at me." But a couple of minutes up the road I said, "I swear I saw a UFO." He said, "Don't be stupid! It was probably a helicopter." I said, "It wasn't making any noise. It was just sitting on the ground. Anyway, after a few jibes at me, he forgot all about it, and we arrived at [my girl friend's place].

When we were there, my friends bring up this conversation, about what I thought I had seen. Her father says, "You think you've seen little green men or something, Kelly?" and all this sort of stuff. It was turned into a joke, and I just totally forgot about it.

We went out and played bingo. We came back. We had a bit of a problem about what time we left. As far as my husband's concerned, because we got home at 2:30 in the morning, it means we must have left at one o'clock. But that night I think we left at a quarter to 12. We got back from bingo at about 11, and we didn't stay for very long because [my friend's] daughter's boy friend had

just . . . split up with her and had gone home with the new girl friend . . . and she was really upset and crying, and we didn't want to stay. So we weren't there for that long at all.

THE ENCOUNTER BEGINS

Anyway, we were driving back down the road in the same stretch. Both of us, just me and my husband . . . we both saw this thing, mind you . . . in front of us, hovering above the road. It was just something sitting there. . . . I couldn't tell what it was. We were at first far away, but as you got closer to it was sort of . . . well, it wasn't like the orange light in the field. It was a round shape with some sort of glass around, or what looked like windows and lights around the bottom. Because it was dark, you couldn't really tell at first. But as we got closer and closer, there was no noise or anything.

Even my husband's going, "You're right! That's something. That's very, very strange." And I swear we saw people in there, and then just as I said to him, "I swear there's people in there," it just shot off to the left as fast as it could go. I mean it just disappeared. Within a split second it had gone.

We kept driving and about a kilometer ahead, all of a sudden, there's this really, really bright light in front of us, and I've got my hand up, up above my brow, to look out the window, because it's *that* bright, but I can't see anything.

I said to [my husband], "What are you going to do?" He said, "I'm going to keep driving." From there, that is the last we remembered until . . . I knew I was going to see a UFO, you know, I just knew, because of what we had seen, I'd seen it twice in one night and he had seen it once . . . and the adrenalin is pumping, the heart is thumping, I'm so excited. All of a sudden I'm sitting in the car, and I'm saying to my husband, "What happened?" And he says to me, "I don't know. We must have gone around a corner or something."

By the time we got home, he was definite of everything, but at that time he didn't know what happened either. I said to him, "I swear I've had a blackout," because adrenalin just doesn't disappear in a split second like that. I mean your heart is going mad! And all of a sudden. . . .

One thing that really annoyed me was that I could smell vomit. I couldn't figure out where the smell of vomit was coming from.

I argue about this half the way home until it started getting ridiculous, and I ended up just shutting up to stop all the fighting that was going to come out of it, you know, because we fight like cats and dogs. . . .

As we were getting close to our home, about 20 minutes away from where we live (there was no one on the road), I saw a figure standing on the side of the road—a tall dark figure. It was only for a couple of seconds, and

I didn't relate it to anything until much later on at all. But it made me turn my head. I kept it in my mind, because it reminded me of a story I was told when I was a little girl about the headless horseman on the side of the road . . . because it was on the side of the road. It wasn't headless or anything, just this tall black figure. I saw it for only a couple of seconds, and then I couldn't see it anymore, but I thought I saw it.

POSTENCOUNTER FALLOUT

I get home. That night I actually had a dream about UFOs to top it all off, that something happened . . . but a whole lot of it went out of my head.

Kelly and her husband argued about what happened for part of the way home. They agree they saw a UFO but cannot agree on the feeling Kelly had of experiencing a blackout or missing time and seeing people. They also could both smell vomit. Each experienced unexplained stomach pain. For Kelly it was like a pain from severe muscle fatigue which radiated from her lower abdomen to the upper shoulders.

Later, after they got home, Kelly experienced menstrual bleeding and became quite ill. She had had her period only the week before. Eventually she entered the hospital with a womb infection. The doctors there said she must have been pregnant; either that, or she had had some kind of gynecological operation. In fact, she had had neither in recent times. A strange triangular mark was also found on her abdomen along with a scar.

Kelly elaborated on these matters:

But when I got home that night, that's when I found the triangular mark below my navel, with what I thought was a little laparoscopy cut, and I also started bleeding that night. Three and a half weeks later I ended up in hospital. . . . [The hospital] actually did a laparoscopy, another laparoscopy. This was not when I first went in. I went back in later, another six weeks after that, because I had a lot of pains in my stomach and just wanted to have it checked to see what it was. And I still had the triangular mark there. . . .

They just did a blooming laparoscopy cut right next to it. [There was] no comment whatsoever. . . . I have a letter from a friend saying that she saw it.

CONSCIOUS RECOLLECTIONS

Kelly's recollections did not come from any hypnosis. Indeed she had only one session well after the main investigation had been completed. It failed to reveal anything of significance. Feeling that at best she had been only lightly under, she felt the session had been of little value.

With regard to the August 8 encounter, she recalls crossing the road to the paddock, seeing at first one tall black being with glowing red eyes, then many. These latter seemed

to be approaching rapidly, as if gliding. The large group of tall black beings apparently were split into two groups, one focused on Kelly and her husband, the other one on the other people who had also crossed farther down the road. The rest of her recollection is largely confusing and fragmented. She experienced voices and blindness.

Kelly elaborated on how her memory came back:

We went down to a girl friend's place a little bit later, a few weeks later, and the subject of UFOs came up, and her husband was saying, "Oh, I don't think they really exist." It was my husband that said, "If you had seen what Kelly and I saw, you might change your mind." I said, "What are you talking about?" You know, if I'd seen something, I'd have remembered it. I didn't even remember that I had seen it hovering in the middle of the road. It had been totally blanked out of my mind. And I search my head for days, because I knew he wouldn't say something if he didn't mean it. He was telling me, "Remember, on the way home from [your girl friend's], remember, it wasn't making any noise?" And I was just sitting there. I couldn't remember it.

And a few days later, all of a sudden I remembered it! It hit me! And . . . then I remembered going into the light, and then I couldn't remember anything else.

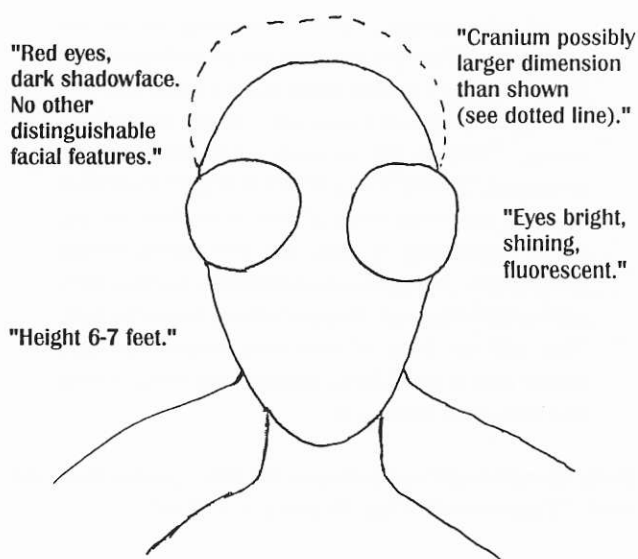
A couple of weeks after that, this started to really bug me, because I remembered that light, and I remember arguing with him all the way home, but it was all I did remember.

I went up to [my girl friend's] house again in October, this time for her other daughter's . . . birthday, and again we went to bingo. On the way home from bingo that night, we went along the same road, and as we passed a certain spot I just got this incredible feeling of terror go through me, I mean absolute terror. All of a sudden I just started remembering, and by the next morning I had remembered just about everything that happened, except there's still missing time that I can't.

What we had actually done, we had driven . . . into the light, but the road curved, and the light we had thought was in front of us was actually to our righthand side. It was in the field, and it was massive. . . . [Estimates put the possible diameter of the UFO at the "size of a house" or perhaps close to 50 meters.] So it was very big. Why I knew it was very big was because we could have driven for five minutes. The road sort of wound around this part. You could have driven for five minutes and not had it out of your sight the whole time.

Kelly and her husband had a clear, uninterrupted view of a craft of enormous size. It was much larger than the UFO seen a few minutes earlier, and it was at ground level in the field at the bottom of a gully area.

I asked him to stop the car, and we both got out. I remembered leaning back in, actually on the floor, to



Author's sketch of being (based on drawing by Kelly Cahill).

pick up my handbag, because I didn't go anywhere without my handbag. And that's one of the sort of things that triggered off a lot of these memories doing that. The other thing was telling myself, "You are conscious. This is real! This is happening! This is real!" . . .

For a while it was just absolutely terrifying, but you can't help it because it sounds really wacky. I mean this is not the way it's supposed to happen at all. . . .

We crossed over the road. We jumped the gutter, and we walked up. . . . I looked down the road, and there was another car—a light blue car—pulled up. Some people got out and went across the road. I only thought it was two, but it was actually three, but I didn't pay much attention. They must have been at least a hundred meters down the road from us. When you've got something like that in front of you, and you've got people down the road . . . well, I was more interested in what was in front of me than them, so I didn't get any detail. . . .

I'm standing there, and we are looking at this thing [for about 30 seconds]. All of a sudden there is a black figure on the field. It's about seven foot tall. . . . I knew it was really tall at the time.

For Kelly this was quite startling. She expected to see a human being, but this was not human. Kelly tried to use thought as a means of communication. She was immediately overwhelmed with fear. Its eyes seemed to turn to a red fire. At the distance of about 150 meters, they possessed an extraordinary luminosity.

It started coming towards us, only slowly, and it had big red eyes. It sounds stupid, but it had great big round red eyes, like huge flies' eyes and they were red like, not like a reflection of red, but like burning red, like . . . fluorescent stop lights, I suppose, that sort of real burning red.

All of a sudden I started screaming out [to my husband]. . . . Now this has really got me baffled because of the fact that a human being doesn't know this, so I don't even know how I came out with this, but I started saying, "They've got no souls." And then I started screaming, "THEY'VE GOT NO SOULS!" Then all of a sudden there were heaps of them in the field, not just one, a whole heap of them, and they started coming towards us . . . faster than a man could run, and they were gliding off the ground. They got halfway across the field. They split up. Some of them went towards the other people [two or three, Kelly thought], and some of them [the rest] came towards us.

Kelly found herself screaming to the other people down the road, "They're evil! They're going to kill us!"

The next thing I know, I felt this *umph!* in my stomach, right across here like I was winded, but I was thrown right back, and I was on my back on the ground. I sat up, with my head between my knees. Here, I'm trying to stay conscious. I couldn't see. My eyes. . . . It was all black. . . . I'm screaming out to [my husband]. . . .

Kelly speculated that her "winding" may have been caused by an electric fence present at the site. That may or may not be true. The fence may not even have been on at the time. Even if it was, the power may not have been strong enough to generate the effect she described. Nonetheless this possibly prosaic incident led her into confusion over whether the forces she was confronting were "good" or "evil."

But the next thing I heard him saying, "Let go of me." His voice was all sort of cracked up with fear, and I'd never heard that from my husband. He's not frightened or afraid of anything. . . .

Then this male voice said, "We [don't] mean you any harm." And then he said, "Why did you hit Kelly then?" That's the last I heard of [my husband]. No one else talked except me. I heard the male voice. Then I heard myself saying, "Oh, God, I'm going to be sick." I've got my head between my knees, and I just felt, like, violently nauseous. Then I must have blacked out for a little while. I don't remember being sick. Then I remember hearing talk about being a peaceful people, and I started screaming out, I said, "Don't believe them! They're going to steal your souls!" I know it sounds so ridiculous now, but at the time I was hysterically terrified. . . . I had never felt terror like that. Not even in my worst nightmares had I experienced terror like that. . . .

Oh, there's one thing I remember that he said: "I wouldn't harm her. She's my daughter." Now when I first saw the—on the way up to [my girl friend's] in the field, the first thing I did was pray. And I took it as

sarcasm straight away. And it sounded like sarcasm. . . . It sounded like there was even a small laugh after that. I don't know—it just wasn't good to me.

For Kelly, a strong faith in God often involved an ability to get answers to many of life's situations, albeit sometimes in the most subtle and unlikely ways. For her the brief observation of a possible UFO on the way to her girl friend's place on August 7 was perhaps a glimpse of one of life's mysteries, perhaps even a lesson from God. So she made a silent prayer which began with "Father." She thought for a moment, "Wait for me. I'll be back down this way in a few hours."

To put this in context, it should be pointed out that Kelly had long been on a spiritual quest, anchored in a religious journey and a desire to understand the great mysteries. Though she had little time for organized religions, she had a deep interest in the great religious works and had studied them, particularly the Bible, in great detail. Therefore, given her brief prayer for clarification of the nature of the UFO event on the way up to her friend, as well as the use of the word Father, she got a sense of "mockery" when she heard the voice saying, "She is my daughter."

Anyway, I started screaming and going on about demons trying to steal people's souls. . . . I like not to admit that it came from my mouth, but it did. . . . But I'm going to tell it the way it is.

Next thing I hear him saying, "Would somebody do something about her?" And I felt a hand . . . touch my shoulder. It wasn't hard. It was quite gentle. That's when I absolutely cracked! I'm still sitting on the ground, and I couldn't see a thing, but I made sure that my eyes were just fierce. . . . Something snapped in me. Before that I was crying. All of a sudden something snapped in me, and I got so angry. Then I started screaming out, "How dare you do this to these innocent people?" Like it was my fault. Because I was on a big spiritual search, and I really got the impression that it was my fault. And I thought, why involve other people? . . . I felt like, almost like there was a fight for me. Like it was something I had to do. . . .

Anyway, I started screaming out stupid things, told them to go back where they came from.

Next thing I remember I was sitting in the car. I've still got missing time.

When she found herself sitting in the car, her last memory was of driving into the light.

THE DREAM OF AUGUST 8, 1993

Once she was home and asleep, the night brought a bizarre dream.

This dream is of interest in that it emerged within hours

continued on page 18

EPISTEMOLOGICAL TOTALITARIANISM: THE SKEPTICAL CASE AGAINST ABDUCTIONS

BY THOMAS E. BULLARD

I had to think twice—and then some—when I received an invitation to speak at a CSICOP conference in Seattle this June 23rd. The Committee for the Scientific Investigation of Claims of the Paranormal has always been dead set against taking UFOs seriously. These guys wear the black hats, after all, and I was supposed to confront them on the proponent side, not just for UFOs in general, but for abductions, the most fantastic aspect of the UFO phenomenon. Philip J. Klass would be there, of course, and I wondered what weird social dynamics might arise when a mass of skeptics came together (about 700 of them, as it turned out). Visions of human sacrifice to the God of Reason troubled my sleep.

Perhaps it was a streak of missionary zeal that took hold of me, a wish to preach to the sinners and not to the choir for a change, or the bravado to beard the lion in its own den. Klass had the nerve to show up at the MUFON symposium year after year, and even seemed to enjoy himself. Maybe I was missing something. More than that, I saw a legitimate angle of attack, a chance to express some long-standing complaints with the way skeptics treat the abduction phenomenon. I would challenge their science, or lack of it, and argue that abductions amounted to an anomaly deserving serious inquiry, whatever their ultimate nature might be. Now, there was a position I could defend. I accepted the invitation and gave myself up for dead.

The original lineup for the UFO abductions panel included two proponents and two skeptics. Speaking in support of a genuinely strange phenomenon were psychiatrist John E. Mack and folklorist Thomas E. Bullard; speaking in favor of a more prosaic solution were psychologists Robert A. Baker and Nicholas Spanos, whose findings that UFO experiencers were psychologically normal had received considerable media attention a few months earlier. Two days before I departed for Seattle, Paul Kurtz telephoned with the unhappy news that Dr. Spanos had been killed in an airplane crash two weeks earlier. Baker praised

Dr. Spanos as a prolific and able researcher, Mack honored him as a rational and gentlemanly opponent. The ufological community can be grateful for his contribution to our understanding of the human dimension in the UFO experience.

Kurtz added new speakers to fill out the panel. They included Sharon Filip, a professional therapist and an abductee who had worked with Mack, and William Cone, a skeptical psychologist.

Baker argued that every aspect of the abduction phenomenon could be explained in conventional psychological terms. All the content needed for such reports came from movies, tabloid yarns, and countless other media influences. Investigators with agendas based on personal belief led subjects to fantasize abduction stories, whereas investigators with other agendas might coax their subjects to imagine past lives or prophecies of the future. The typical abductee was fantasy prone and suggestible, especially under hypnosis, and eager for the recognition that comes with abductee status. A sense of experience derived from sleep disorders and hallucinatory phenomena closely allied to sleep. The stories themselves were false memories at best and hoaxes at worst.

Bullard countered that the consistency of abduction reports set them apart from typical fantasies or hoaxes. So many media influences, so much opportunity for creativity within the structure of these fantastic stories, raised our expectation that they would vary a great deal, yet they did not. Tests of the fantasy-prone hypothesis and predictions of the distorting effects of hypnosis had failed. A common argument for media influence claimed that the 1977 movie *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* established the short, large-eyed humanoid in public consciousness as the right way for an alien to look. An examination of abduction reports published before release of the movie showed that this sort of alien was already quite common, thereby disproving another skeptical explanation. Whatever the ultimate nature of abductions, they were certainly anomalous and deserved the scientific investigation that skeptics preach but all too seldom practice.

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MACK ATTACK

The speaker farthest out on a limb was Mack. His conclusion that abductions represent a real and revolutionary encounter with intelligences beyond the scope of our present understanding set him up for the closest scrutiny by a skeptical audience. He emphasized that he did not start out as a believer, but found too many sincere and compelling reports to sustain his initial doubts. Children as well as adults told similar stories. These people did indeed come from all walks of life. One was a candidate for political office, many held responsible professional positions demanding high-level skills and intelligence. Such people stood to gain little and lose much by reporting an abduction experience. They had no need to seek recognition in this way, and showed no signs of mental disturbance—in fact the only psychological trait they often share resembled the emotional aftereffects of a profound, even traumatic experience.

He felt that the abduction experience marked an opening of new knowledge, perhaps a new way of knowing as well. The rationalistic polarities of mental and physical, subjective and objective may have proved too rigid and narrow to encompass the reality of human experience. Abductees often returned from their encounters with new understanding, more flexible and tolerant in their thinking. Perhaps they were leading the way out of the limitations of prevailing modes of thought.

Filip added her personal perspective to some of Dr. Mack's points. Her abduction experiences seemed as real to her as any other experience. They had been a part of her life for many years and turned her toward her career as a mental health professional. She neither sought publicity nor suffered from a personality disorder, and praised Dr. Mack for his skill and insight in helping her to better understand her experiences.

William Cone has an unusual distinction among skeptical psychologists—he has actually worked with a number of abductees in the course of his practice, and can base his judgments on clinical experience. His evaluation of abductees as a group was not flattering: The dollar motive drove some of them to claim abduction, the spotlight of publicity or attention lured others. Some had a loose identity and a fluent ability to assume fictitious roles. At worst abductees were mentally ill, suffering from a delusional disorder. He dismissed the abduction phenomenon as a combination of hoax, fantasy, and bad research from investigators serving their own interests and wishes. Such harsh criticism prompted someone in the audience to ask later if all the claimants who came to him belonged in the categories he described. He had to answer no.

A final speaker came as something of a surprise. Donna Bassett is a reporter who achieved notoriety in April by undertaking an exposé of Mack's investigations, reported in *Time*, April 25, 1994, pp. 74–75, after claiming to be an abductee and undergoing the facilitative techniques he uses to recover hidden memories. Her husband worked at *Avia-*

tion Week and Space Technology in the 1970s, along with Klass (who denied being responsible for her presence). She now took the podium to confront Dr. Mack with her criticisms.

And scathing they were: She claimed that he accepted her fictitious story without question, and had a naive willingness to credit any yarns as long as they confirmed his expectations. On one occasion when he became especially caught up in her story, he leaned so heavily on the bed where she reclined that it collapsed. Mack violated basic medical ethics by failing to obtain the informed consent of his subjects. No scientific method added rigor to his investigations, while his memory facilitation techniques were tententious and demanding, leading the subject to "recall" false memories. When he cited the value of children's testimony, he did not mention (and perhaps never found out) that one mother had severely pressured her young son to tell Mack a suitable abduction story. The social milieu of his abductee gatherings contributed to the development of a mythology and had much in common with a cult. The shared fantasies of the group produced mimicry and paranoia. His abductees were in general emotionally needy, troubled, and abused. They sought satisfaction in their role as abductees, even as he sought confirmation for his personal beliefs in their stories.

Mack denied her allegations point by point. He admitted that a duly prepared and determined individual could deceive him, but pointed out that he did not find Bassett's story convincing enough to include in his book. The exchange amounted to one person's word against another, and she had compromised herself already by her willingness to misrepresent herself.

As soon as the audience had a chance to question and comment, someone spoke out against the ambush tactics of bringing on Bassett unannounced. A loud round of applause followed. It was not clear whether the notice was short or nonexistent, but a number of people felt the confrontation lacked due consent and was therefore unethical.

The rest of the questions were less supportive. Some of them reflected hoary misconceptions, like abductions were strictly North American phenomena, or similar ideas in folklore and literature meant the reports must be false. Others attacked abductees and even the appropriateness of inquiry, prompting Mack to ask why should we persecute abductees and add to their difficulty in discussing their experiences? Meaningful inquiry into the phenomenon did not require holding the captain's log in hand. The skeptics' attitude that they were embattled defenders of reason while their opponents promoted only ignorance and superstition echoed an intolerance that amounted to epistemological totalitarianism.

THE SKEPTICS' CASE

The value of a conference extends far beyond formal presentations. A talk over breakfast, the questions and reactions of

the audience, the way speakers present their evidence and arguments, lend deeper insights into the thought patterns of the participants than a sheaf of published articles. A ufologist confronts the skeptic with preconceptions. They are unavoidable, perhaps, but a burden he must drop for the sake of understanding the opposition and how it thinks. What follows are some personal observations and suppositions in an effort to grasp the skeptical perception of the abduction phenomenon.

The CSICOP membership impressed me immediately with its high level of education and intelligence. They are questioning and tough-minded, at home with intellectual rigor and impatient with fuzzy thinking. They demand rational, scientific standards before they accept a proposal as true—they want solid evidence, experimental proof, and look immediately for a conventional solution to any unconventional claim. The skeptical worldview has only sharp edges and blacks and whites. Shades of gray and shadowy corners do not exist, leaving no place for credulity and unexamined beliefs to hide.

UFO abductions find no toehold in such an environment. What looms largest in the skeptical mind is the failure of abduction claims to measure up to minimal standards of proof. The shortcomings in evidence for an objective event pile up quite a list:

- The stories are fantastic at face value. They oblige us to believe UFOs swarm through the skies day and night, capturing people not by the dozens but by the thousands, on a scale more nearly industrial than scientific or exploratory. We must accept that the aliens have found this needle of an earth amid the starry haystack, and now whole fleets of them traverse interstellar distances to do nothing more than capture and examine humans using similar procedures over and over again. They seem to have no time left over even for sightseeing. If we try to make sense of what the aliens are doing, they seem to be taking genetic materials and creating hybrids—a good high-tech, superscientific activity, but they appear to go about it the hard way. These beings who are so far in advance of us in spacefaring technology must have fallen behind in biotechnology, since even current earthly techniques could accomplish most of their goals with a small amount of genetic material. Still they duplicate their efforts endlessly, with no more imagination than wind-up toys. So many implausibilities strain skeptical credulity far beyond the breaking point.

- The experience has a surrealistic, dreamlike quality. Abductees describe themselves as floating through the air, semi-conscious, as if on Valium. They pass with ghostly immateriality through closed doors and solid walls. The experience occurs in isolation from normal time and space—an hour or two slips away unaccounted, a vacuum surrounds the scene as crickets fall silent and traffic disappears. Abductions take place in plain view, even in the middle of a city, yet passersby are unable to spy on the aliens at work. Little wonder that skeptics regard such a dream-like experi-

ence as a dream in fact.

- We have nothing but the testimony of claimants for evidence. Most of these claimants are alone at the time of the alleged encounter, often asleep when it begins, often observing in the dark of night. This testimony is far too weak to overthrow our entire understanding of the way the world is.

- Physical evidence of any sort is ambiguous or nonexistent. None of the alleged implants recovered from abductees have demonstrated an extraordinary character. None of the ground traces or bodily markings credited to alien activity demand an unconventional explanation. None of the supposed missing fetus cases stand up to close examination. All artifacts brought home from the spaceship have mysteriously disappeared. The absence of this most convincing form of evidence convinces the skeptics that they are right.

- Memory of the experience is usually less than lucid. Claimants may describe themselves as groggy, controlled, afraid, or otherwise impaired in their ability to observe and think clearly. Recollections may emerge only after a period of time, and appear in disarticulated images or scenes. Many details surface only with the dubious assistance of hypnosis. The quality of primary observations in abduction cases falls far short of controlled laboratory standards.

- The abductee as an individual is largely an unknown quantity. How susceptible these individuals are to fantasy and suggestion, whether a proneness to sleep paralysis, hallucination, or lucid dreaming might furnish the experiential basis for an abduction story, what sort of life background they have that might facilitate confusion of a subjective experience with a real event—all these important variables remain largely unexplored. What we know about the fallibility of memory, and what we are beginning to learn about false memory syndrome, underscore a human capacity to reinvent the past in creative ways that may bear important consequences for the abduction phenomenon. Ufologists have paid little attention to these factors; skeptics turn to them first for their answers.

- Abduction investigators, well-intentioned as they may be, bring questionable skills to their exploration of this phenomenon. These investigators also bring their own beliefs—perhaps their own agendas—rather than dispassionate objectivity to their work. Under these circumstances the skeptics rightly worry that dangers of confabulation and investigators leading the witness always lie close at hand.

- There is still a sucker born every minute—or has the birthrate increased since the last century? Claimants seeking money, publicity, or attention, who bring considerable skills of deception (or self-deception) to their presentations, find a willing audience among naive investigators anxious to hear their beliefs confirmed and unwilling to question the stories objectively. The claimants and investigators combine reciprocal needs that are fatal to the discovery of truth.

- Abductions have become the darlings of the media. No one can pass through life in the conscious state these days without learning the basic grammar of this phenomenon. It appears in movies, television shows, advertisements, car-

toons, best-selling books, magazine articles, newspaper features, tabloid yarns, and popular fiction. Exposure is now inescapable, while experiments with hypnotized non-abductees from nearly twenty years ago demonstrate that subjects with no detailed knowledge of the UFO literature can create a passable facsimile of the typical abduction report. There is no mystery to where abductees get the content of their stories.

- Abduction reports certainly reflect cultural influences to some extent. The abductees of Britain prefer aliens that are tall blond "Nordics," while North Americans favor short gray humanoids, though the British pattern has changed since 1987 when the cover of Whitley Strieber's book *Communion* became well known. Since then the number of short gray aliens has increased in British reports. In years gone by the aliens left messages warning about nuclear testing and the dangers of radiation; in recent years the aliens sermonize on the dangers of ecological destruction. No objective phenomenon should conform so readily to the changing expectations of the times.

- Accounts of kidnap by unearthly beings are nothing new under the sun. The religion, mythology, and folklore of the past are full of the same motifs we hear today in abduction reports. Almost every culture on earth has beliefs about diminutive supernatural beings. Often they come in the night, like fairies, and carry off mortals to a supernatural otherworld for breeding purposes or population replenishment. Time may run at a different rate in fairyland, paralleling the missing time element in abduction reports. The examination episode resembles myths of initiation, where a candidate seeking the powers of the shaman visits the underworld, where demonic beings perform a gruesome dismemberment operation, and sometimes implant a magical crystal into his head. In some traditions, the judgment of the dead includes an instrumental examination in an underworld chamber as the gods weigh the soul on a scale. Nothing is unique about the abduction story.

- Abduction accounts have the character of folklore for the modern age. We no longer believe in ghosts or fairies or ogres. The supernatural no longer holds central position in our worldview, yet we have not changed so much after all. We still have fears and uncertainties, perhaps a desire to be scared and a faith in powers greater than our own. We replace our old superstitious dreads with urban legends of mass murderers and escaped lunatics with hooks for one hand. We can also believe in aliens whose powers are not magical but superscientific, who can threaten us against our will, or bring messages of salvation from the heavens. These aliens fulfill the age-old functional category of supernatural assailants, but adopt an acceptable modern guise.

LIARS AND DREAMERS

This formidable battery of objections sums up much of the skeptical case against abductions. Are they reasonable? Not in the way described. Curious aliens may well exist in the

universe and explore other planets, but extraterrestrials are not flocking here for the single-minded purpose of hybridization. Our knowledge of nature is far from perfect, but we are not completely at a loss. The speed of light seems to be an absolute limitation on travel, and hybridization by the process featured in abduction reports is all wrong for an advanced civilization. The abduction story as it stands has to fall because it violates both our scientific knowledge and our common sense.

The surrealistic qualities of the accounts point toward their true origin. Flotation, passing through walls, missing time, and the vacuum effect may spell superscientific technology at work, but this explanation amounts to a science fiction rationalization, not a defensible reason. A simpler answer is a subjective one. These effects reflect the dream-like nature of the abduction experience and locate it in mental space, not outer space.

All the content for the stories has its antecedents, age-old in religion, mythology, and folklore, more recent in media influences bombarding the public with abduction imagery. All the raw materials are there. What brings out the stories and holds them together in the illusion of a genuine phenomenon is an active cadre of investigators with preconceptions to confirm. For them the abduction phenomenon is a lifework, a quasi-religious faith, a personal quest for meaning in their lives. All objectivity has gone out the window, self-deception has taken over. These investigators press a subject to tell them the story they want to hear, leading, demanding, cuing, and encouraging the narrator, facilitating the process with hypnosis, until confabulation shapes a proper abduction story out of unpromising fragments of imagery.

Much responsibility for the abduction story lies with the abductee. I discussed the subject with one perceptive skeptic, and he divided the abductee population into three classes: one group consists of deliberate liars, publicity seekers, and mercenaries—the hoaxer contingent. A second group belongs to fantasy-prone, confabulating, deluded, or delusional individuals—the psychological contingent. The third group contains people who describe their experiences and feelings as accurately as they can, but misinterpret and distort the events under the influence of abduction expectations—the honestly mistaken contingent.

This blunt division encompasses all abductees and leaves no remainder to sustain the claim of a genuine mystery. If the phenomenon has experiential aspects, they belong to the anomalistic psychology of sleep paralysis and hypnogogic or hypnopompic hallucinations. If the memories seem real and outside any previous learning by the subject, they result from false memory syndrome or cryptomnesia, the recall of hidden memories left over from movies, readings, or other conventional sources of abduction imagery.

A rational examination of abductions demolishes their strangeness step by step. Conventional explanations come readily to mind for every aspect, and offer a better alterna-

tive to the claim that these stories are literally true. Reason and science expect the claimants to prove their case, but no proof has been forthcoming. In keeping with their mythical nature, abduction claims escalate in scope and strangeness without a shred of evidence for support. Persuasive physical evidence has not come to light, while the claims remain untested and untestable. The abduction myth is a faith, a figment of wishful imaginations, and nothing more. Such is the skeptic's case.

THE SKEPTICS' FAILED CASE

No one can deny the persuasive power of this argument, and it will satisfy many people that a subjective answer settles the issue once and for all. I would agree as well, if these objections told the whole story. The truth is, they do not. What remains to be said is that the objections are not as straightforward and unshakable as they seem. They do not always square with the evidence, nor do they reckon with all of it. The skeptical argument excludes a body of findings that show abductions in a different light, revealing a more complex and puzzling phenomenon than skeptics usually allow. Here are some reasons why the continued interest of ufologists rests on a basis of evidence rather than of faith:

- Not all abduction reports depend on the testimony of a single witness. Multiple-witness cases comprise a minority, but an important minority. More important still is the fact that these witnesses tell similar or complementary stories. People go to jail on that quality of evidence.

- Not all reports depend on hypnosis. A sizable minority of abductees describe their experiences from spontaneous recall, and most of them access part of the story without hypnotic intervention. The danger of hypnosis for generating false or distorted memories is a serious concern, but subject to test. Those tests show no difference in content whether the reports are revealed with or without hypnosis, and neither have the predicted effects of a hypnotist's personality or expectations left their apparent marks on the narratives. Those experiments with hypnotized non-abductees compare with "real" reports in the range of alien types described, but differ in distribution. Every non-abductee came up with a different type of alien, while abduction claimants describe humanoid types again and again. The distorting effects of hypnosis lie in the predictions of critics and not in test results.

- The skeptics' psychological assumptions about abductees owe more to wishful thinking than to sound evidence. Some claimants are hoaxers or delusional, but a growing literature of psychological studies of abductees (e.g., Sprinkle, Parnell, Ring and Rosen, Rodeghier et al., Stone-Carmen, Spanos et al.) reveals that these people are not fantasy prone or psychologically aberrant. The only thing disturbing about them is how normal and diverse a group of people they are. If some want publicity, many others avoid it like the plague. A psychological or motiva-

tional common denominator that would explain abduction claims in conventional terms has yet to be found.

- Abduction reports maintain an unexpected consistency from narrator to narrator, year after year. My comparative study from 1987 found a surprising consistency in the sequence of events in abduction reports, and a recurrence of content that includes both familiar elements and unpublicized details. A recent survey of 13 investigators adds further confirmation, since the survey results agree (to the limits of one standard deviation) with findings from the 1987 study in 54 out of 63 descriptive story elements. Some early results from Dan Wright's abduction transcription and comparison project also fall into line with these earlier findings.

Differences exist in reports. Every recurrent characteristic like the rounded examination room or the short humanoid occupant has its alternatives, but they run to 20% or fewer with a typical regularity of their own. This very regularity in alternative descriptions reinforces the impression of overall stability in the reports.

My training as a folklorist teaches me that this situation is unusual. Narrators recombine story elements, replace them with new ones or borrowings from other stories in a ferment of creativity that no brevity, mundaneness, or close-knit structure of the narrative can hinder. The notion that only one version of a narrative exists and everyone repeats it as if reciting from rote memory is a fallacy. Folktales like *Cinderella* never circulated in the storybook version, but in as many variants as there were narrators. The general *Cinderella* plot circulates worldwide and many motifs or segments of the plot turn up in one version after another, but not with anything like the recurrent stability of the abduction story.

- Abduction stories are unlike fantasies in a number of important ways. If the reports are more or less alike, they lack the strong individual element necessary to satisfy personal needs. Abductions offer little comfort or peace to many abductees. They feel more troubled than pleased by the alleged experience. The personal element seems slight in these narratives, while an impersonal core turns up again and again, a core that seems imposed from outside rather than generated from conscious or unconscious needs, and provokes strong emotions that seem to defeat the usual purpose of fantasy or hoax.

Fantasy and hoax call for variety, not consistency. Abduction stories have fantastic subject matter, loose construction, and considerable length—three open invitations for narrators to exercise some creative license. No logic demands that the examination precede the conference, yet the same order persists even though the story would make just as much sense if these episodes exchanged places. A more entertaining story would result if the narrator went tearing off on "Star Wars" adventures, but the narrators are not adventurous at all and portray themselves only in a passive, victimized role. We can only wonder with surprise what holds these stories together, if they are mere fictions after all.

- An abundance of investigators increases the likelihood of variety, not consistency. If only a few investigators supplied all the reports, investigator influence would seem probable; but reports reach us through more than a few investigators. Fifty of them contributed the 103 high-information, high-reliability cases in my 1987 comparative study. No one individual added a disproportionate number of entries, or outweighed the personal prejudices of other investigators with his own.

The survey of 13 investigators makes clear that they do not think alike. Far from being fanatical supporters of the extraterrestrial hypothesis, only three expressed a strong conviction that aliens performed abductions, and only one of those three took the aliens to be entirely physical beings. Investigators are diverse in their expectations and wishes, interpretation and attitudes—which only adds to the surprise that they find so many similarities in the story core.

- The skeptics' reliance on media influence to explain consistency in abduction reports amounts to misplaced confidence. They are right to argue that chance has little to do with story construction, that fictitious narratives should reflect cultural and media influences, and that those influences might stabilize the narratives. What they miss is how surely stability in abduction stories runs counter to expectation, media or no media. Folklorists have found that people feel no obligation to repeat a media source with accuracy. They vary the message as readily as they vary any other source. Elizabeth Loftus, an authority on memory and eyewitness testimony speaking at the CSICOP conference, confirmed this tendency when she reported experiments with people shown videotaped enactments of a crime. As soon as they retold the story, these viewers altered the content by an average of 64%. All forces of variation ought to operate on abduction fictions whatever their source, yet do not.

Another problem with media influences is that we are exposed to too many of them. The raw materials for an abduction story are widespread in the media and more broadly in other cultural ideas. The concept of extraterrestrials is there, a rich stock of alien imagery, and the notion that those aliens might capture us for various purposes. Just about every idea ever included in abduction stories has its antecedent or parallel in a cultural source. Hollywood has exposed us to a bewildering variety of alien types. Short gray humanoids are uncommon in space movies or folklore, yet with so many picturesque alternatives for the fantasizer or hoaxer to choose from, narrators still return with tedious regularity to something as bland as these little gray beings. The media provide an equally diverse series of plots. Choose action, adventure, romance, travel, horror; save the universe, save the earth, rescue the princess, win fame and fortune. All these options are available, some of them turn up in unreliable reports; but the typical abductee undergoes the same routine of capture and examination at the hands of aliens. If hoaxers want to attract attention, an unimaginative and repetitive story burdens them with a losing strategy.

An amended version of the cultural influence hypothesis stresses the importance of a single movie, Steven Spielberg's *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*, as the source of the small gray humanoids so popular with abductees. This movie is visually impressive and a great many people have seen it. It is the obvious candidate for a major influence, but the facts tell a different story. I found 38 high-information, high-reliability cases that were published or on record prior to release of *Close Encounters* in October 1977. The beings in 15 cases are dead ringers for standard humanoids, or close approximations. Another seven combine important likenesses with important differences, while the beings in 17 cases bear little or no similarity to the standard image. This quick study proves that the humanoid alien existed prior to *Close Encounters* and needed no help from Steven Spielberg.

A PUZZLING ANOMALY

Skeptics can find good reason to reject the abduction phenomenon, but they can find equally good reason to regard it as puzzling, if they only take the trouble to look. I did not start out determined to find consistency in the reports—honest! It fell out of the comparative process as a natural, inherent outcome, voluntarily and without need of coaxing from me. I take this consistency to be a fact about the texts of abduction reports, whatever its origin and the ultimate nature of the abduction phenomenon may be. Any adequate explanation must account for this fact.

The consistency of reports defies simplistic efforts to blame investigators and investigative techniques, or cultural and media influences. Even if abductees are all hoaxers, fantasizers, or mistaken, the likeness of their narratives poses serious problems for current understanding of narrative transmission and promises that valuable scholarship can result from the study of abductions, aliens or no aliens.

Nor is this consistency a metaphysical proposition. It is a finding that follows from data and invites further investigation to confirm or refute the patterns I have identified. The question of whether the stories reflect an unfamiliar or unknown phenomenon falls within the reach of scientific inquiry. Access may not be easy, approaches may have to be indirect, but the necessary ingredients are available to shift the inquiry from armchair speculation to scientific study.

"Puzzling" is the most tenable verdict the current findings allow. They do not prove aliens or disallow them, and the final word on the role of fantasy proneness, false memory, or confabulation under hypnosis cannot yet be spoken. Such indirect evidence as consistency in the reports and the failure to demonstrate fantasy proneness among abductees certainly cannot prove one hypothesis and disprove another. Such discoveries as we have made are simply unexpected and curious. What they do and do well is disprove the quick and easy conventional solutions of the sort proposed by skeptics. Too much in these reports confounds their would-be explanations. We do not know all the answers and have much work to do before we understand this phenomenon.

What abductions are, then, is an anomaly. This anomaly is not necessarily due to unknown phenomena, but neither is it absolutely certain to be conventional. Abductions hold enough interest to stimulate curiosity, enough mystery to offer a chance to learn something new—about human psychology and narrative dynamics, if not about alien life. An anomaly is a good place for science to start, and for that reason if for no other, the abduction phenomenon presents a worthy subject for scientific attention.

SKEPTICS VS. SCIENTIFIC INVESTIGATION

These few conclusions seem to me like a bottom line, a conservative and uncontroversial position even skeptics could acknowledge. Pardon my naivete. The sorry truth is that they have treated the phenomenon more like a topic in dogmatic theology than a subject for scientific inquiry. They claim the scientific, rationalistic high ground, and given the credentials and professions of many CSICOP members, I would expect them to take a genuinely scientific and rationalistic position. Their practice falls far short of their ideals.

I left the conference suspecting that skeptics do not want to investigate abductions. An attitude that abductions are a nuisance and ought to be stamped out seems to have replaced the curiosity that is the driving force of science. A similar hostility appears to confront all paranormal claims. I base this observation on what I took to be a chilly reception for Susan Blackmore's research into near-death experiences, despite her rationalistic approach and conclusions that placed the phenomenon squarely in the realm of conventional knowledge. Perhaps I read too much into these observations, but the skeptical position includes an unmistakable theme that we understand the world well enough with our present knowledge to distinguish what ought to be true from what is incredible. Of course we live by this assumption every day, and could not live without it. It serves us well. Yet I see nothing wrong with entertaining the possibility that unexpected claims offer clues to a world different from the one we know, a world containing novel or unknown phenomena. The likelihood is slim, but the reward potential is great. At least keeping minds open to the possibility until investigation and test clarify the issue strikes me as the proper scientific approach. The skeptical position appears to leave no crack or cranny even for a possibility.

Too much certainty seems to me a dangerous thing. It leads us into a willingness to regard our reason as sufficient to answer questions, at the expense of a humility to ask and inquire. The self-correcting mechanism of science works—witness the way due process settled the cold fusion issue—but we have to give this mechanism a chance. Dismissing extraordinary claims without a hearing is defensive and reactionary. It also leads advocates of science into embarrassingly unscientific practices. Whatever happened to evidence as the daily bread of science? Skeptics have seldom spoken with an abductee, much less undertaken a systematic

inquiry. These claimants are the primary source of information about the phenomenon, and offer rich potential for learning something about the human side of extraordinary belief, if nothing else, yet skeptics usually avoid them. Complaints about anecdotal testimony and the difficulties of learning anything from eyewitnesses, even if they actually witness something, are all well and good, but how far would science progress if its practitioners give up and go home every time the going gets rough?

Not only do skeptics violate sound procedure when they argue without the benefit of firsthand data, but they often select the data they choose to admit without any pretense of evenhandedness. A few examples or cases become the basis for an entire argument, while all sense of proportion vanishes. One occupant of different appearance denies the tendency established by a dozen that look alike. The lack of persuasive physical evidence becomes ground enough to dismiss the whole phenomenon no matter how many other mysteries remain. Skeptics show little mercy for special pleading in other contexts, but adopt it as a basic methodology in their treatment of abductions.

Selectiveness in argument also characterizes skeptical practice. A willingness to point out the positive aspects does not always continue with a responsible discussion of less favorable implications. The media are a potent source of ideas, but an argument for media influence bares this double edge: Many other ideas are available there along with familiar abduction content. The narrative output of fantasizers borrowing their ideas from the media should follow in some degree the variety of input those media provide, or else proponents of media influence should explain why fantasizers thread their way through all that variety to choose the same set of ideas over and over again. Skeptics have tried to find favor on both sides of the argument, wanting abductees to borrow their stories from the media, and to ignore that a considerable problem exists in how the selection process works.

Familiarity with current research amounts to the admission fee for addressing a topic, but many skeptics are unwilling to pay up. The serious research on abductions follows scholarly byways rather than the mainstream, but this research is no less responsible on that account. I found that few skeptics know that a scholarly, refereed journal of ufology exists, or credit it with objectivity. When some individuals learn that Kenneth Ring published his study on the psychological profile of abductees in the *Journal of UFO Studies* and not in an established psychological journal, they dismiss the study as worthless. If it had merit, they argue, a mainstream journal would accept it. An old "catch 22" joke repeats itself here: "I'll believe it when it's published in the professional literature; but I'll publish it only when I believe it."

A basic skill like listening sometimes suffers before the rigidity of skeptical convictions. An example occurred even at the conference: On Thursday night I demonstrated in words and illustrations that short gray humanoids prevailed

in abduction reports before *Close Encounters of the Third Kind*. At a luncheon lecture the next day, the presenter repeated the claim that no standard humanoids populated abductee accounts prior to this movie. If all scientific work took place in this sort of communications vacuum, we would still be living in caves.

The ultimate paradox of skeptical science is its unscientific nature. The operation of fantasy proneness and confabulation in other situations may resemble the operation of abductees' thinking, but some critics seem to forget the distinction between a reasonable possibility and a proven certainty. They leap to the conclusion that because fantasy proneness or confabulation *may* give rise to elaborate fictions, these causes *must* be responsible for abduction stories. Guilt by association may satisfy the true disbeliever, but it looks pretty flimsy to everyone else. And it is certainly not scientific.

Science depends on the testing of hypotheses to sort out maybe from must be. Only by passing tests does the hypothesis become an established conclusion—so we all learn in high school science. Skeptical treatments of abductions seem to take a shortcut. The skeptics promote their hypotheses to the status of conclusions without the intermediate step of testing. This practice saves time, but misses the truth. Fantasy proneness, hypnotic confabulation, and the influence of *Close Encounters* offer plausible explanations and skeptics treat them as such—but testing decides the issue, and skeptics have no tests to back their assertions.

Tests have addressed these hypotheses and they have failed. When a hypothesis fails, its proponents may challenge the tests, rework the hypothesis, or give it up. The skeptics have chosen none of the above. They simply go on as before, forever mired in the past as they repeat the same old claims despite evidence to the contrary, relying presumably on a stubborn faith that appearances cannot deceive. This is no way to do science; this is no way to do any kind of scholarship. Repetition of a refuted claim as if it were fresh and unchallenged amounts to living in denial. The scientific process requires give and take, a willingness to accommodate successive evidence and refutations, then move on to new proposals more suited to the full evidence. Therein lies the difference between rational dialogue and a shouting match, or the difference between the way abductions should be treated, and how they have been treated.

Now, in all fairness, ufologists are far from pure. They are equally guilty of clinging to untenable beliefs and hearing only what they want to hear. The fact remains that it is the ufologists who undertake most serious studies of the phenomenon and approach it in the true spirit of science, however clumsily. They talk to abductees, seek evidence, and test hypotheses. The avowed upholders of scientific procedure leave science in the hands of the Philistines.

This ufologist will not deny the value and necessity of an objective, scientific exploration of abductions. If pet theories have to go, they should go—but only after a fair scientific inquiry. The abduction phenomenon has received

nothing of the sort. I agree wholeheartedly with the skeptics that science is the most successful by far of all human attempts to understand the natural world. My quarrel is not with the ideals of the skeptics, but with their shortcomings in living up to those ideals.

The consequences of those shortcomings extend beyond mishandling an intriguing phenomenon. When I saw the CBS *48 Hours* episode on UFOs some months ago, it was not the experts on either side who impressed me, but the abductees, whose sincerity and visible saneness declared in a persuasive way that something happened to baffle these people. Other viewers probably felt the same way. Science shines when it changes minds by the force of evidence and reason, but nothing tarnishes the image of science like dogmatic assertions posing as science. The public knows the difference, and perhaps senses that something is wrong in this conflict between sincere personal testimony and broad generalizations from the experts. In this case the suspicion is justified. The skeptics have not done their science; their case has more in common with medieval scholasticism than scientific inquiry. But it is science that takes the blame. This is no way to advance the cause of scientific understanding among the public.

Carl Sagan in his keynote address called for an appreciation that people are not purely rational. They also believe, and have need to believe. We do not have to surrender a skeptical attitude toward those beliefs, but we need to allow that they serve human purposes. By implication, the CSICOP attack mode for dealing with beliefs is no way to win friends and influence people. More considerate means of approaching erroneous beliefs might prove more persuasive. That a kinder, gentler CSICOP will result from this plea seems unlikely. I would be happy to see true scientific curiosity replace the fossilized replica of science that skeptical practice now represents. The inquiring spirit has crystallized into an assumption that we can know all we need to know about a phenomenon by reasoning from current knowledge, therefore investigation and test are a waste of time. If the skeptical community applied its impressive vitality, intelligence, and skills toward an unbiased inquiry into abductions, final answers might emerge from the effort, where now we hear only assertions high on confidence but low on evidence. And who knows? The skeptics might even discover that the world has a few surprises left after all. ♦

There's a doctor in the house

Mark Rodeghier, CUFOS scientific director, has just completed his doctorate in sociology at the University of Illinois at Chicago. His dissertation, "Factors Influencing Attitudes toward Controversial Research: Quantitatively Disentangling the Social from the Scientific," examines why scientists either support or don't support SETI or UFO research. Copies will soon be available from the CUFOS office.

SOME WHIMSICAL—AND SERIOUS—REFLECTIONS ON ABDUCTIONS

BY RICHARD HALL

Oh for the good old days when the UFO mystery consisted of geometrical-shaped unidentified objects seen flying around by pilots and honest citizens! Our battle in those days was to convince the leaders of society that these quite ordinary and down-to-earth individuals were reliable witnesses and actually were seeing unidentified *craft* which seemed too extraordinary to be made on earth. Scientists and others, of course, scoffed at the possibility of visiting craft from outer space.

Today we are faced with UFO-encounter story content so bizarre in detail—and yet so seemingly credible overall—that we now try to convince ourselves (if not the leaders of society) that persons who claim they were abducted by aliens and submitted to medical probings are not *necessarily* crazy, and may in fact be telling the truth on some level.

Part of the problem, of course, is that past claims of direct encounters with alien beings in the 1950s and 1960s (the contactees) depicted something altogether different. The aliens then typically were golden-haired, idealized beings who selected humans such as George Adamski to spread their message of peace and brotherhood on earth and took them on *voluntary* voyages to other planets to see for themselves what we poor, benighted humans were missing. (Never mind that no two of the contactee stories were alike, or supported by any consistent view of the visitors' home planets.)

Today's alien visitors are depicted as diminutive, bald, cold, manipulating little bastards who would not likely win any popularity contests or take any Nobel prizes for preaching that there will be a better future for humanity if we only see the light and accept their philosophy. If we accept the standard (and all too disturbingly consistent) story that emerges from reputable abduction case investigators, we are faced with beings who routinely practice what would be obvious crimes if adjudicated in human courts: kidnap, rape, unauthorized medical experimentation, tampering with evi-

dence, and obstruction of justice. Not to mention harassment, stalking, and other unacceptable human behavior.

Then we get complicated and murky multi-feature cases which tend to polarize investigators into an all-or-nothing interpretation and to cause division within the research community. The cases often center on one individual or one small geographical area with unprecedented numbers of sightings and all the earmarks of hysterical contagion. Some of the individual sightings, however, are credible.

Just like the problem of interpretation in the contactee era, what are we to make of the alleged concern of the modern aliens about environmental destruction that we are bringing on ourselves? This is a pervasive theme in the emerging abduction encounter story.

I recall thinking in the contactee era, if these people really care, why don't they simply use their obviously superior powers to alter our self-destructive behavior? The "Space Brothers" always excused themselves on the grounds of being prohibited by cosmic law from interfering. Well, is not the overt proselytizing and preaching of the contactees a form of attempted interference? Furthermore, unless there is some hidden relationship between them and us, why should they give a damn one way or the other?

Something analogous occurs to me today. If the modern, cold, ugly, manipulative alien experimenters are for real, why are they (as presumably galactic or interdimensional travelers) so hung up on our society, our remote and insignificant outpost in the universe? One possible answer that springs to mind is that we must have something that they want or need. Another is that perhaps, as Charles Fort suggested long ago, "we are property." We are a colony of beings they monitor and perhaps guide and protect, for unknown reasons. Maybe we are genetic relatives bound together by circumstances now lost in prehistory.

SMOKE AND MIRRORS

An emerging theme is that we have genetic stock, and a psychological and emotional reservoir, of which they are envious and trying to absorb or emulate for the advancement

Richard Hall, an IUR contributing editor and longtime figure on the UFO scene, heads the Fund for UFO Research.

of their race. How conveniently flattering to our human egos! Here are these beings who, according to all reports, far surpass us in terms of their understanding and manipulation of natural forces, but for all their technological superiority they are in awe of us because they have lost the ability to feel and lack the genetic stock to complement their advanced brainpower.

This sounds suspiciously like wishful thinking to armor ourselves with the notion that we have an edge on them and ultimately are in control. It should be manifestly clear by now that we have no control whatever over them, other than the admirable individual, personal resistance many abductees display when faced with intrusive and unwelcome beings who are continually trying to force them to do or passively accept things against their will.

A now commonplace feature of abduction experiences is the Running of Humans by Psychological Testers from Outer Space. In one recent example a man and two small children are fleeing monsters, become trapped, and have only two receptacles in which to hide. The man tries to fit both children in one receptacle, but that doesn't work. Must he sacrifice himself so that they can escape harm? The monster images in these cases seem real, but are they possibly holographic projections or the alien technological equivalent?

Time after time abductees have been confronted with apparently deliberately staged but real-seeming moral dilemmas, usually involving physical actions, and put through their paces, run like rats through a maze, forced to make difficult or impossible choices. In other instances abductees are told that some cataclysm or terrible event is about to happen and they should prepare for it. These predictions, of course, never come true. I envision alien psychologists monitoring the tests and recording the results—the reactions they get from humans—in their mental computers. They appear to be studying what makes human beings tick.

Most important of all, it is becoming clear that the aliens are playing a smoke-and-mirrors game with us on several levels. What you see may not be what you think you see. I view this as the most important, central issue of abduction research: If the aliens are playing mind games with us, how can we trust anything our senses tell us? What is real, and what is staged illusion? Was that handsome blond human in the Travis Walton case really a projection staged by the small gray aliens to calm Walton down after he threatened to get out of control?

Is the whole interbreeding and baby-presentation phenomenon nothing but an alien scam, staged to make us think about our place in the universe and our relationship to beings who look and behave differently from us? Are we being conditioned by alien psychologists to improve the quality of life in their experimental colony whose environment we are destroying through irrational behavior?

Are the "aliens" really ancestral natives of the earth environment? Have they always lived clandestinely within and among us? When we start acting up and endangering our

mutual environment, do they intercede?

Most anything is possible, but alternatives to the face-value interpretation of abduction encounters must be considered while we attempt to sort out what may be real and what may be illusory. Our work is cut out for us. ♦

DANDENONG—*continued from page 8*

of the encounter and it places Kelly back in the encounter. The subsequent "dreamings" do not have this quality about them. Nonetheless they were unusual in their own way, for reasons that will shortly be apparent.

In the August 8 dream she is on the side of the road with her head between her knees. She becomes aware that she can see again. A being is leading her husband down the slope onto the field.

Throughout the dream she is unable to see the beings above the level of their elbows. Their limbs seem long and thin.

Inexplicably convinced that the being with her husband is female, she tackles it and then blacks out. In the dream she once again regains consciousness to find herself on the extreme right of the field with the UFO further down the field to the left. Before her on the ground is a still body, at first nonhuman, then changing to human. A middle-aged woman standing further down the field is screaming at her, "Murderess! Murderess!" She is overcome with grief with no awareness of having killed anyone.

Still in the dream, a hand on her shoulder leads her, and she follows obediently. Eventually Kelly becomes aware that she is in a small room, with only a small table and a being standing before her. The being tells her she did not kill anyone and they had to use her sense of morality to overcome her fear. Kelly has a profound feeling that she knows this being. On a table behind the being is a Bible, one of hers, which had disappeared a few weeks before. The being gives Kelly a strange choice which deepens her suspicion of the beings' motives. She is told she can come but must leave the Bible behind. In the dream the being gives her this Bible.

The dream ends at that point. A few days after the encounter, her husband found the Bible in the car.

The "dreamings" mentioned earlier, first interpreted as something like a ghostly episode, take on a bizarre perspective when Kelly's recollections flooded back. The first two preceded the point when more complete recall of the events of August 8 returned.

THE "DREAMINGS"

The first started with a presence which warns her to be calm. Then a frightening "sucking" sensation begins as if something is being taken from her. She comes out of the dream terrified and is confronted by a tall black figure in a floor-length hooded cloak, about seven feet tall, with glowing red eyes. She screams, and the being disappears.

Initially Kelly interpreted the being as like a "soul vampire" or the Grim Reaper. At the time she did not place this incident in a UFO context, since the memories had yet to resurface.

In the second "dreaming" she experiences her legs being lifted and drawn out of the bed. She wakes and once again finds the same or similar being present, but this time the cloak obscures the eyes.

When after I did remember it, I had another dream, and these dreams seemed very physical. I know I'm dreaming, and I've got to wake up out of them. . . .

In this particular one, I felt as if my legs were being pulled off the bed, and it was like I was paralyzed from my waist down, and my legs were being pulled over to the side; yet I could almost use the top of my body. Then I'm grabbing a pillow, trying to hit my husband, to wake him up. . . . I'm fighting this. I'm not going to let this thing drag me off the bed by my legs. Then I woke up and saw it standing there again! This time the hood covered the eyes, and it didn't scare me. . . . I was still terrified, but it didn't scare me quite as much, because each time it scared me, it was that same power like I felt out in the field that night.

When I was sitting on the ground, it was like something, almost like a frequency or a sound vibration or something. And it's getting right into my head! And I couldn't get it together. Like I was trying to get my logical thoughts together, not logical, almost conscious thoughts, and I was fighting it the whole time, which is probably why I seemed to remember more than my husband or even the other people.

The third "dreaming" occurred at a friend's place on October 23 (see front cover). By then Kelly had experienced the flood of recollections. The two earlier "dreamings" took on an added significance, especially given the presence of the beings after Kelly had awakened from her "dreamings." This time she wakes from a "dreaming" which seems to take the form of a "peak experience" (as psychologist Abraham Maslow calls it; Richard Maurice Bucke defined it as the sense of "cosmic consciousness"). She sees apparently the same creature as before; but unlike earlier manifestations, it is naked and leaning over her as if about to kiss her navel area. It is tall, with a head much larger than normal, long and thin arms, with an abdomen out of proportion to its thin frame, like a child's stomach suffering from malnutrition. Its skin is like gray-black plasticine. Kelly's screams turn into an "uninterrupted stream of hysteria" and words.

In the morning she insisted that her husband check under the car. She had heard a distinct voice during the night urging such a check. He ignored her request, but their car subsequently suffered such a problem.

Numerous other "psychic" events and "electrical disturbances" followed. Frequently their car started up when no one was inside it. The vehicle had a kill switch which

rendered these events even more startling and curious. Kelly thought she had developed enhanced psychic powers. The electrical events apparently ended in January 1994, as did many of the psychic incidents.

The fourth "dreaming" occurred in January of this year. In the dream the bathroom light is blown. There is a sense of presence. Something persistently tries to grab Kelly's right hand. Eventually she lets her hand be taken. Immediately she wakes up. Once again the creature in the black robe is standing by her bedside. It goes away. It turned out that the light had indeed blown and that diamond and sapphire rings she wore on her right hand had disappeared. To date they have not been found.

OTHER MATTERS

Other, earlier episodes, experiences, and issues of possible significance:

- From July through September 1993 small orange fireballs, about the size of tennis balls, frequently hit the windows of the house. Kelly, her husband, and her mother witnessed the phenomena.

- About two and a half years earlier, at Lator, Kelly had a peculiar dream in which she moved through a fleshlike hourglass apparatus. The same night she experienced a "vision" of opening their back door and seeing a light for a few seconds. Then she blacked out. Kelly experienced the same sense of power she felt in the field in August 1993.

- After the encounter and until July 1994, the Cahill house (built in 1949) had been the scene of fleeting observations of tall "shadows," seen by both Kelly and her husband. A bad smell occasionally permeated the house and seemed to move around.

THE OTHER WITNESSES

If the August 8 encounter had revolved only around Kelly, it could be argued that the experience may have been some sort of psychological episode. But the presence of other witnesses—a married couple and their friend, plus a possible other observer in a third car—forcefully argues for a real encounter. Indeed, the PRA contends that the focus of the incident was not Kelly but the two other women.

As in Kelly's situation, the females in the other group seemed to play a dominant role. Bill, the male witness in the trio, appears, like Kelly's husband, to have had only limited involvement. The two women consciously recalled onboard episodes. They remembered the UFO and the tall black beings. Their description did not feature the red eyes Kelly saw.

For the trio the experience apparently started when they approached the site. All three could hear a strange noise and suddenly felt ill. Bill thought he was going to faint. He lost control of the car and ran off the road, striking a pole. After checking for damage, they drove off. A few minutes later a speeding car with its high beams on shot past them. Then

another passed. They came to a bridge with a sharp turn following it almost immediately. Farther along this section the trio stopped. As all this was going on, Bill's vision was impaired. Obviously he had some type of vision as he was driving, but he was unable to remember seeing the UFO. The two women with him recall the UFO clearly, and their descriptions closely match Kelly's.

In some unexplained manner Bill was isolated from the central experience. He has conscious recall of smells and sounds and remembers that a lot of activity was going on. He does not recall seeing anything. He subsequently underwent hypnosis, which expanded his apparent recollections to seeming onboard components, but once again these were through the senses of smell and hearing only.

The two women did not think of theirs as an "abduction" experience. They felt as if they had exercised free will all through it. Yet the principal element of their onboard experience was a form of examination—not, however, visually remembered. Other parts of their onboard experience exist in visual images and conscious memory. Hypnosis in their cases appears to have only reinforced what they recall already.

The entities did not speak and provided very little information. Neither woman saw the other or any of the others while in the alien environment presumably aboard the UFO. Curiously, each was still aware of what was happening to her companion, ostensibly through psychic means.

The trio apparently did not have the complex background experiences described by Kelly. Their experience seem limited only to the August 8 encounter.

There is also some physical evidence. PRA found a possible related ground trace and low-level magnetic anomaly at the encounter site.

COMMENT

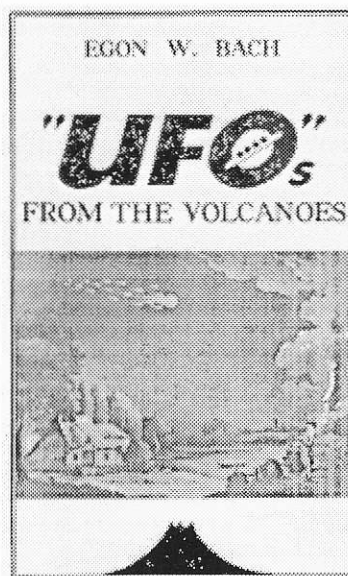
Kelly has gone on to write her own account of the experience and its difficult aftermath. In October 1994 John Auchettl and PRA, whose investigative thoroughness is to be commended, released a comprehensive report on the affair.

In this emotionally explosive area it is easy for people to get caught up in less than satisfactory situations while they attempt to understand extraordinary experiences. I hope this event and the documentation that flows from it will be of some help to others in similar situations.

The victims of these experiences must not be unrealistically encouraged by advocates of an alien presence; nor, at the other extreme, should they be ridiculed by the skeptical among us. They should be helped to deal with their experiences, whether those experiences turn out to be prosaic or profound in origin.

The second part of this report will review the PRA report and examine in detail the accounts of the other group of witnesses. It will also consider the physical evidence and provide reflections on the nature and meaning of this event. ♦

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AIR FORCE REPORT—continued from page 3

officer who initially identified the wreckage as a balloon. Comparison of all information developed or obtained indicated that the material recovered near Roswell was consistent with a balloon device and most likely from one of the Mogul balloons that had not been previously recovered. Air Force research efforts did not disclose any records of the recovery of any "alien" bodies or extraterrestrial materials.

There are two important points to note immediately. It is clear from this summary that the Air Force couldn't find any physical evidence that proves or documentation that clearly states that a balloon from Project Mogul was recovered by rancher Mac Brazel or officers from the 509th Bomb Group. Second, the Air Force has no Mogul balloon material from 1947 to show to witnesses to provide a positive identification; given the many years since the project ended, it is not surprising that no material can be located. Still, without such confirmation, the Air Force explanation relies upon inference from verbal testimony, not solid, hard evidence.

THE AIR FORCE CONCLUSION

Given this lack of evidence, how can the Air Force conclude that the debris near Roswell was from Project Mogul? The key statement in the Executive Summary is the phrase "Comparison of all information developed or obtained." This statement does not say "Comparison of all information available" about the incident, and that is the crucial omission (and admission) of the Air Force investigators. The Air Force certainly read almost all major publications on Roswell, including books by Randle and Schmitt, Friedman and Berliner, and the *Roswell Report* published by CUFOs, so they were aware of the many witnesses interviewed by the investigators. Nevertheless, they confined their interviews to only two former Air Force personnel: Sheridan Cavitt, the Counter-Intelligence Corps officer who accompanied Jesse Marcel to the ranch site; and Irving Newton, the weather officer at Carswell AFB in Fort Worth who identified the debris in Ramey's office as a standard weather balloon. They also interviewed three surviving members of Project Mogul.

Given the many, many persons who have been identified as firsthand or secondhand Roswell witnesses, that the Air Force interviewed only five people is truly astonishing. Two key former military personnel whom they did not interview were General Arthur Exon, who confirmed the presence of two sites and a gouge in the ground, and Jesse Marcel, Jr., who handled the debris his father brought home. Nor did they try to interview any of the other living military witnesses mentioned in the two books by Randle and Schmitt, including Walter Haut, who distributed the press release and still lives in Roswell.

Many Roswell witnesses have passed away, but interviews with some were recorded before their deaths. One would expect that the Air Force investigators would be interested in such material, but they never requested the tapes on which Bill Rickett, former second-in-command to Cavitt, discussed his knowledge of the crash and recovery, or the tapes on which Edwin Easley, Provost Marshall at Roswell in 1947, admitted that he was still sworn to secrecy about the event (which would not be true for Project Mogul after all these years).

Except for Project Mogul personnel, the Air Force also decided not to interview civilians with knowledge of the event, including Glenn Dennis, the mortician who claims he talked to a nurse who assisted with autopsies on alien bodies; Bill Brazel, son of Mac Brazel; or Loretta Proctor, a former neighbor of Mac, who saw some of the debris and talked to Mac about it.

The Air Force's explanation for their curious lack of interest in certain witnesses is explained on page eight of the report:

While the historical document search was in progress, it was decided to attempt to locate and interview several persons identified as still living who could possibly answer questions generated by the research. . . . Again, the focus was on interviewing persons that could address

specific issues raised by research and no consideration was given to try and locate every alleged witness claimed to have been contacted by the various authors. For example, one of the interviewees thought vital to obtain an official signed, sworn statement from was Sheridan Cavitt, Lt Col, USAF (Retired) who is the last living member of the three persons universally acknowledged to have recovered material from the Foster Ranch. Others were also interviewed as information developed.

We surely couldn't expect the Air Force to interview every person named in the literature on Roswell, but to have interviewed only five persons calls into question the serious intention and true goal of the investigation.

The Air Force investigators did examine thousands of pages of documents. They found no mention of the Roswell incident and the recovery of any debris, except known documents such as the FBI telex of July 8, 1947. Nor, as noted above, did they find any documents that conclusively linked Project Mogul to the Roswell debris, even when they obtained private records and, in one instance, a professional diary of A. P. Crary, another Project Mogul staffer.

How, then, did the Air Force decide that a Project Mogul balloon was the source of the Roswell debris? Even though their reasoning is not laid out this neatly in the report, here are the key facts as the Air Force sees them:

1. Their search of official records turned up no "information that the 'Roswell Incident' was a UFO event." Nor was there any evidence for the existence of any classified program that is concerned with the storage or exploitation of the debris from Roswell, assuming it was from an alien spacecraft.

2. There is "no indication in official records from the period that there was heightened military operational or security activity which should have been generated if this was, in fact, the first recovery of materials and/or persons from another world."

3. Project Mogul was flying instruments from Alamogordo Army Air Field (now Holloman Air Force Base) whose purpose was classified top secret. These instruments were flown on huge balloon trains composed of many balloons and radar reflectors and so would have provided a substantial amount of potentially unusual debris.

4. Sheridan Cavitt claimed, in his interview of May 1994, that he immediately recognized the debris as part of a balloon.

5. Irving Newton, in July of this year, and consistent with what he has maintained all along, stated that what he saw in General Ramey's office was debris from a balloon.

6. The story about the Roswell event in the July 9 edition of the *Roswell Daily Record*, quoting Mac Brazel, provides a description of the debris that is reasonably consistent with Mogul balloon material.

7. The photos of debris taken in General Ramey's office are consistent with material from a balloon and radar reflector, and Mogul staffers shown the photos felt the material could have been from one of their balloons.

8. *Some* of the witness testimony is consistent with material from Mogul balloon material, such as the alleged use of a purplish-pink tape with symbols on it to hold the assembly together.

WHAT ROSWELL WAS NOT

Before reviewing the testimony and reasoning the Air Force used in the report, we note that the Air Force investigation actually supports the work of Randle and Schmitt, who have previously been able to show that the Roswell object could not have been a V-2 rocket, an experimental aircraft or aircraft crash, or an atomic accident of some kind. The Air Force found no evidence that the Roswell incident was caused by any of these terrestrial sources, which is further proof of the quality of prior investigation on Roswell by UFO researchers. The upshot of this elimination of other terrestrial sources by the Air Force is that there remains *only one possible conventional source* of the Roswell debris: a Project Mogul balloon train.

PROJECT MOGUL

Although reports in the media, and the Air Force report itself, seem to indicate that the balloon found near Roswell was a top-secret Mogul balloon, the story is more complicated than that. Project Mogul was designed to determine whether acoustic devices could detect atmospheric shock waves from Soviet nuclear explosions. In 1947 the Soviets had not yet successfully exploded an atomic device, but we knew they were working to develop this capability. Since it was at that time not possible to fly spy planes easily over Soviet territory, we needed another long-range method of monitoring their atomic tests, and one idea was a balloon-borne, low-frequency acoustic device that was developed by personnel connected with New York University. The project was eventually abandoned when the concept was found to be unworkable. Several flights were made in June and July of 1947 that could conceivably be the source of the Roswell debris.

Two types of flights were conducted by the project. One type was a test of the actual Mogul device and associated instrumentation; the other was labeled a "service flight" by Project Engineer Charles Moore and was not always logged. All flights seem to have been accounted for, in one way or another, except for Flights 2 through 4, and Flight 9. Although Flight 9 was much closer in time to the recovery of debris, the Air Force suggests that Flight 4 was the source of the debris. Given the existing Mogul records, it is clear that Flight 4 would have been launched no later than June 4. We return to this point below.

These earlier flights used neoprene meteorological balloons. The report notes that "Professor Moore stated that the neoprene balloons were susceptible to degradation in the sunlight, turning from a milky white to a dark brown. He described finding remains of balloon trains with reflectors

and payloads that had landed in the desert: the ruptured and shredded neoprene would 'almost look like dark gray or black flakes or ashes after exposure to the sun for only a few days.'" To remain at constant altitude, a Mogul balloon actually consisted of several balloons, as shown on the front cover of this issue. This multiballoon array with associated radar reflectors, the Air Force suggests, came down on the Foster ranch and was found by Mac Brazel on June 14.

They base this date on the story in the July 9 *Roswell Daily Record*, where Brazel is quoted at length. In fact, the Air Force relies heavily upon this newspaper story, the photos in Ramey's office, and their interviews with Cavitt and Mogul personnel.

THE REPORT'S INTERNAL INCONSISTENCIES

One way to criticize and expose the weaknesses of the Air Force investigation is to demonstrate the implausibility of certain conclusions or statements. Another is to bring evidence to bear from other witnesses and sources that undermines the evidence presented in the report. A third, which we pursue in this section, is to show that there are serious problems of contradictory testimony and evidence *within the report itself* that call into question the Mogul explanation. To keep this article from running on endlessly, we focus here only on the most glaring inconsistencies.

Extent of the debris. Sheridan Cavitt's signed statement to Colonel Richard Weaver claims "The area of this debris was very small, about 20 feet square." The July 9 newspaper article that the Air Force uses as evidence quotes Brazel as stating that "The rubber [from the balloon] was smoky gray in color and scattered over an area about 200 yards in diameter." These statements can't be made to match. One of them must be wrong.

General appearance of the debris. Flight 4, if it was the cause of the debris, must have lain in the sun for at least ten days (from June 4 to June 14). Professor Charles Moore stated flatly that after some exposure to the sun, neoprene would turn into "dark gray or black flakes or ashes." Neither Cavitt in his interview, nor Brazel in the newspaper story, described finding this type of debris, even though the sun in June in New Mexico is quite intense at the high altitude of the Foster ranch. Once again, key witnesses provide contradictory testimony.

Type of balloon. Brazel told the newspaper reporters from the *Daily Record* that "he had previously found two weather balloons on the ranch, but that what he found this time did not in any way resemble either of these." This statement has never been possible to square with the original Air Force explanation that a weather balloon was the source of the Roswell debris. It also remains difficult to reconcile with the new balloon explanation because Flight 4 did not consist of any unusual balloon material, despite the highly classified nature of Mogul. Flight 4 simply consisted of several standard balloons. This is evident as well from the testimony gathered from Irving Newton (assuming he was

viewing debris from Flight 4), who stated that "this was a balloon and a RAWIN target [the radar reflector]." Additionally, in his signed statement made during his interview, Cavitt claimed that "I remember recognizing this material as being consistent with a weather balloon." The Air Force can't have it both ways. Brazel said the stuff did not resemble a weather balloon; Cavitt and Newton say it did.

Symbols on the debris. According to Colonel Albert Trakowski, the Air Force project officer for Mogul, a purplish-pink tape with flower and heart symbols on it was used to hold some of the flimsy Mogul balloon train together. In his newspaper interview, Brazel does mention "some tape with flowers printed upon it" that had been used in the construction. However, Cavitt, who must have had a good, long look at the debris during the recovery, stated at one point that "I do not remember any writing at all on the thing [debris]." Even later, after being further prompted by Colonel Weaver, the interviewer, he still said, "I don't remember anything like that." If Cavitt's memory is correct, a major part of the Air Force evidence is discredited. And if we are to discount his testimony on this point, why should we accept his statements about other aspects of the event?

Once again, we have contradictory evidence and testimony within the Air Force report, requiring us to accept testimony selectively from one source or another if we are to agree with the Air Force explanation.

Many other oddities could be mentioned, but one more must suffice. Cavitt said that he never met Brazel, but he also admitted recovering material from the debris field. One of us (MR) knows full well how difficult it is to find the debris field without guidance from a local. There is no way that Marcel and Cavitt could have driven from Roswell to the debris field without being shown the way—all the way—by Mac Brazel. That being the case, then Cavitt certainly did meet Brazel. If his memory is so poor about such an obvious fact, what else is he misremembering or still not telling?

THE REPORT'S LOGICAL INCONSISTENCIES

The most glaring, we believe, are the radically different evaluations of the debris by Marcel and Colonel Blanchard, commanding officer at Roswell Army Air Field. If Cavitt so easily recognized the debris as a downed balloon, as did Irving Newton in Fort Worth, why didn't Marcel and Blanchard? There is no logical explanation, especially because we have to assume that Cavitt and Marcel did not stand mute on the debris field, but instead talked about the material and its possible origin. And if they talked at all, then Marcel and Blanchard should at least have been cautious about going public.

The Air Force, in its report, is aware of the difficulty of explaining Blanchard's and Marcel's actions. The best they can suggest is "that there was over-reaction by Colonel Blanchard and Major Marcel." Over-reaction indeed! Now there's an understatement. The boys at Roswell put out a

press release, informing the world that the balloon they captured was a flying disc and jeopardizing the security of Project Mogul, even though the head counterintelligence officer has told them the debris is from a balloon, and the best explanation is "over-reaction." This explanation is made even more ludicrous by the successful careers that Marcel, and especially Blanchard, had in the Air Force after this monumental blunder, which should have resulted in instant demotion for them if their actions were what the Air Force is now claiming.

It is clear from their testimony that neither Moore nor Athelstan Spilhaus, former director of the NYU Balloon Project, heard of the Roswell incident until approached by investigators. This is simply not believable if the Roswell incident was caused by one of the Project Mogul balloon flights. The events at Roswell must have been a notorious and embarrassing incident for the Army Air Force. For security reasons, it is inconceivable that key Mogul personnel were not told the Roswell debris was definitely a Mogul flight. There would undoubtedly be discussions about better security arrangements after this well-publicized farce (which came close to blowing Mogul's cover). Yet Moore did not remember that Mogul had caused the Roswell incident when Bill Moore interviewed him around 1980, and Spilhaus says he was unaware of the incident until contacted this year by the Air Force. That the Air Force does not address this issue is very troubling.

A third point which doesn't make much sense, if the Air Force theory is correct, is that Jesse Marcel and his family kept some of the debris after the incident and even showed it to the Cavitts. Mary Cavitt, Sheridan Cavitt's wife, sat in on the Air Force interview, just as she had done during Randle and Schmitt's interviews. At two points, she stated that Jesse brought out material when the Cavitts were visiting. After her interjection, Cavitt himself said, "I remember. He could have had some there at the house and it was, it looked like a foil of some sort, and he could have tried to burn that and it didn't burn very well. I don't know."

Look closely at Cavitt's statement. First he said he remembered. Then he qualified his statements with the word "could," and finally he ended with "I don't know." This sounds to us like a man forced by the admissions of his wife to discuss an issue he would have preferred to avoid.

The key question is this: If Jesse Marcel knew that the material he and Cavitt recovered was from a balloon, either weather or Mogul, would he have kept some of the debris around the house and brought it out and still played around with it, as if there was something special about it? Obviously not, if the debris was only from a standard balloon, since weather balloons were common in the Air Force. But if the debris really had strange properties, then he might keep it around for later viewing and study, only showing it to other military personnel, like Sheridan Cavitt, who had accompanied him to the site. And, too, he might keep it because he knew the public explanation for Roswell was a cover story, one that had used him as a scapegoat, so he wanted to retain

evidence to prove his original evaluation was correct.

INVESTIGATIVE WEAKNESSES

By now it should be apparent that 1) the Air Force cannot prove that debris from a Mogul balloon train was the cause of the Roswell incident, and 2) the report is self-contradictory and logically inconsistent. The Air Force was quick in their report to criticize the work of UFO researchers because “almost all their information came from verbal reports many years after the alleged incident occurred. . . . Most, however, related their stories in their older years, well after the fact.” That description applies almost perfectly to the Air Force report, which relies nearly exclusively upon such evidence.

Even though Project Mogul documentation exists, there is no paper or physical evidence to prove conclusively that a purplish-pink tape, for example, was used in constructing the balloon trains. Yes, former Mogul personnel claim it was so, but their statements are simply “verbal reports many years after the alleged incident occurred.” The same is true for all the critical elements that might link Project Mogul to Roswell.

Colonel Weaver, head of the Air Force investigation, admitted as much to Cavitt during the interview. He stated, in response to Cavitt’s wishing him good luck at convincing people of the Mogul explanation, that “. . . it is going to be difficult, because like I say we have nothing other than this one formerly classified project that was occurring out there at the same time that was even a little bit ‘funny,’ if you will.” This is a telling admission of weakness because, *if* the source of the Roswell debris was something unusual but conventional, *and* there was only one project going on in New Mexico that might have caused it, *why* should it be difficult to convince us that this project—Mogul—was the cause? The answer, as Weaver must be aware, is that the Air Force case is weak. They, like the UFO investigators they criticize, rely on verbal reports and selective use of existing accounts.

What makes the Air Force report inferior to the best Roswell investigations is its refusal to use all the available testimony, especially their star witnesses. If, as the Air Force claims, time makes memories hazy, then you would expect them to use statements from Charles Moore from around 1980 rather than 1994, since Moore’s memory 14 years ago is likely to be more accurate. This is particularly true because, in the meantime, he has read much UFO material by his own admission.

However, the Air Force completely ignores the following key statement Charles Moore gave to Bill Moore in 1980: “Based on the description you just gave me, I can definitely rule this out [that Roswell could be a weather or other scientific balloon]. There wasn’t a balloon in use back in ’47, or even today for that matter, that could have produced debris over such a large area or torn up the ground in any way. I have no idea what such an object might have been, but I can’t believe a balloon would fit such a descrip-

tion.” That is a damning statement that completely refutes the Mogul explanation. Since the Air Force couldn’t explain why a key witness has changed his testimony, they found it convenient to ignore previous interviews. We though, are not bound by such artificial restrictions, so have to question why Charles Moore has now changed his mind. In any case, we usually accept the first statements made by a witness, before any contamination has set in. On that basis, Project Mogul could not have been the cause of the Roswell debris.

There is one other flagrant lacuna that confirms to us, at least, that the Air Force was not interested in conducting an in-depth investigation into Roswell: the lack of thoughtful and insightful questions by Weaver as he interviewed Cavitt. Earlier we noted the bizarre situation in which Cavitt was able to recognize balloon debris immediately, but Marcel and Blanchard could not. Since this is such a puzzle, you would expect a competent interviewer to ask Cavitt what he told Marcel and what Marcel said in return as they discussed the debris on the ranch. But this matter was never raised by Weaver, making it obvious that he was not interested in pursuing every potentially important lead. Nor did he delve, after Mary Cavitt’s comments, into what the Cavitts knew about the debris that Marcel kept at his home. It should have been obvious that the nature of that debris was crucial to the investigation.

We have demonstrated how little compelling evidence there is for the Air Force’s theory that a Project Mogul balloon array caused the Roswell incident. Why, then did much of the media so blindly accept the Air Force’s conclusion? A full answer to that question must await another article, but we can note here the double standard applied to the UFO subject by the press. Just imagine that the Air Force had released a report on some other topic, a report in which they 1) admitted that originally they had lied, and 2) the “real” explanation was still fairly similar to the lie. Can anyone believe that the American press, given their general distrust of the military, and the history of government cover-ups during the Cold War, would automatically believe the new explanation? Yet that is exactly what much of the press has done with Roswell. It truly does boggle the mind.

The Air Force report has not halted the GAO investigation or reduced the resolve of Rep. Schiff, who told CUFOS that he is determined to continue his efforts at learning the truth about Roswell. We thank and applaud him for his resolve and political courage. In this article, we have criticized the Air Force report without resorting to much of the evidence collected by investigators over the past fifteen years. When that information is brought to bear, the superficial nature and inherent bias of the report are even more apparent. Although it is very helpful to have Sheridan Cavitt on the record, as well as the Air Force itself, the Air Force report is useful for little else, and it does not contribute toward solving the puzzle of the nature of the debris found near Roswell in 1947. That is truly a shame, given what could have been accomplished. ♦